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Dear Members of the INFORMS Prize Committee,

I am writing in enthusiastic support of Professor Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I had the privilege of taking his course, IE 5374: Applied Generative AI, during my MS in Engineering Management at Northeastern University. Few courses leave a measurable footprint on a student's career trajectory within a single semester. Professor Dehghani's did. The skills, mindset, and portfolio I built in his class are the direct reason I secured my co-op offer at Berry Dunn McNeil & Parker LLC, as a Copilot Product Development and Management Intern.

What sets Professor Dehghani's course apart is its insistence that students build, not just study, the frontier of AI. The class is anchored in a deliberate progression that moves from understanding the internals of large language models, including tokens, embeddings, temperature, and text-splitting strategies, through architecting retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) pipelines, designing agent memory and context-handling logic, and finally deploying working multi-agent systems. We worked hands-on with LangChain, CrewAI, LangGraph, and workflow tools like n8n. By the end of the semester, I was no longer treating LLMs as black boxes; I understood why a chunking strategy matters for retrieval quality, when to use a ReAct agent versus a deterministic workflow, and how to evaluate whether an agentic system is actually solving the user's problem.

The direct career impact has been substantial. When I interviewed for the Copilot Product Development and Management Co-op at BerryDunn, the technical depth I drew on, including RAG architecture, vector databases, agent orchestration, prompt-engineering patterns, and the trade-offs between deterministic workflows and agentic decision-making, came almost entirely from this course. I was able to speak fluently about Microsoft Copilot Studio, Azure AI Foundry, and governance frameworks because Professor Dehghani had taught us to think about deployment, evaluation, and responsible use alongside the model layer itself. I am now applying that same foundation at BerryDunn, where I am helping build an AI-driven bid/no-bid decision system for the firm's government contracting pipeline using XGBoost, RAG, and LLM-based scoring. The line from his classroom to my work product is short and direct.

Beyond technical skills, Professor Dehghani cultivates AI literacy in the truest sense. He teaches students to ask sharper questions about what these systems can and cannot do, where they fail, and how to design around their limitations. That judgment is what employers are actually hiring for in this market, and it is what his course delivers. I can think of no instructor more deserving of recognition for translating OR/MS practice into the next generation of AI-enabled professionals. I offer my strongest possible endorsement of his nomination.

Sincerely,

Snigdha Aleti

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